

L^AT_EX for Elegant Humanities Handouts in Conferences and Classrooms

Corey Stephan, Ph.D.
coreystephan.com

July 5, 2026

The world's best established software system for typesetting and document formatting, L^AT_EX has been popular throughout the mathematical and physical sciences for decades.

The utility of L^AT_EX for scholars in humanities disciplines, however, tends to be overlooked.

L^AT_EX can be used for typesetting in most instances in which a scholar of humanities needs to present our materials.

I prepared these slides in L^AT_EX – with less frustration than would have been possible in graphical presentation program (e.g. LibreOffice Present) – as 1 file:

[github.com/historical-theology/latex-talks/blog/main/icms/medievalist-latex.tex](https://github.com/historical-theology/latex-talks/blob/main/icms/medievalist-latex.tex)

This Tutorial

In this tutorial, I will introduce attendees to L^AT_EX, as well as to the use of L^AT_EX for a common task in medievalist scholarship, namely, typesetting texts with unusual line length and other organizational needs, such as primary texts with our original translations.

The specific ‘thought experiment’ will be that of determining how to prepare a handout for a historical conference or class presentation with perfectly organized excerpts of a Byzantine Greek text and an original English translation in parallel.

What is $\text{\LaTeX}$?

It might be best to start to understand what $\text{\LaTeX}$ is by understanding what it is *not*.

A word processor, such as LibreOffice Writer or Microsoft Word, presents material in a (W)hat (Y)ou (S)ee (I)s (W)hat (Y)ou (G)et (WYSIWYG, “whizzy-wig”) style. While one writes, one is simultaneously thinking about and working on formatting.

In a typesetting language, such as $\text{\LaTeX}$ (or ConTeXt or Typst, among others), one is only concerned about the *structure* of what one is writing. One declares that specific characters will be in certain categories of writing ‘things’ (heading, paragraph, footnote, accent type, typeface, etc.), and one allows the program to compile one’s writing as ‘code’ into a tidy final document – every time.

Getting Started with $\text{\LaTeX}$ in GNU/Linux

- ▶ latex-project.org
 - ▶ official recommendations for $\text{\LaTeX}$ **distributions**
 - ▶ $\text{\LaTeX}$ **distributions** are community-maintained bundles of closely interrelated software, including the $\text{\TeX}$ backend, $\text{\LaTeX}$ itself, and hundreds to thousands of packages that extend $\text{\LaTeX}$'s functionality
- ▶ *BSD or GNU/Linux? **TeXLive**
- ▶ MacOS? **MacTeX**
- ▶ Microsoft Windows? **TeXLive** or **MiKTeX**

TeXLive is available in the official package repositories of most *BSD and GNU/Linux operating systems. To install the complete TeXLive distribution (which the ℒ_AT_EX project recommends for newcomers) on one of the most popular libre Unix-like operating systems, one could type:

Debian/Ubuntu

```
apt install texlive-full
```

Fedora

```
dnf install texlive-scheme-full
```

Arch

```
yay -S texlive-meta
```

FreeBSD

```
pkg install texlive-full
```

2 community-built, libre guidebooks

I recommend

The Not So Short Introduction to ℒ_AT_EX

github.com/oetiker/lshort

Dr. Hayes helpfully recommends

Modern ℒ_AT_EX

github.com/mrkline/modern-latex

Simple Setting of Parallel Text in L^AT_EX

There are many ways to set parallel text in L^AT_EX.

The *simplest* is to use the community package called `parallel`, which is included in TeXLive, MiKTeX, and other L^AT_EX distributions. For full documentation, visit:

ctan.org/pkg/parallel

To start using `parallel` in any L^AT_EX document, simply include the following in the preamble:

```
\usepackage{parallel}
```

Here is an abbreviated form of the preamble to this Beamer (L^AT_EX presentation class) file with the most important entries, including parallel:

```

\documentclass{beamer}
\usetheme{Goettingen}

\usepackage{listings}
\usepackage{parallel}

\title{\LaTeX\ for Medieval Primary Source Handouts}
\author{Corey Stephan, Ph.D. \break}
\href{https://www.coreystephan.com}{coreystephan.com}}

\begin{document}

```

Using the parallel package

Basic Format

```
\begin{Parallel}{{< left adjustment >}}{{< right adjustment >}}  
    \ParallelLText{{< left text row 1 >}}  
    \ParallelRText{{< right text row 1 >}}  
    \ParallelPar  
    \ParallelLText{{< left text row 2 >}}  
    ...  
\end{Parallel}
```

Example

```
\begin{Parallel}{{0mm}}{{0mm}}  
    \ParallelLText{Ave Maria ,}  
    \ParallelRText{Hail Mary ,}  
    \ParallelPar  
    \ParallelLText{gratia plena ,}  
    \ParallelRText{full of grace ,}  
\end{Parallel}
```

Ave Maria,
gratia plena,

Hail Mary,
full of grace,

Advanced Setting of Parallel Text in L^AT_EX

For *advanced* scholarly setting of parallel text in L^AT_EX, one ought to learn the 2 interconnected and frequently updated community packages `reledpar` (for parallel typesetting specifically) and `reledmac` (for typesetting academic editions in general), which are bundled with TeXLive and other L^AT_EX distributions.

These 2 packages are specifically designed for long-form academic parallel texts, and they are meant to replace older methods of academic parallel text preparation in L^AT_EX that you might find in Web searches.

For full documentation, visit:

ctan.org/pkg/reledpar

ctan.org/pkg/reledmac

Remember them in the preamble to your document:

```
\usepackage{reledpar}
```

```
\usepackage{reledmac}
```

Setting of Non-Latin Text in L^AT_EX

The most important package for handling text outside of Latin alphabets is the community package polyglossia, which is (as you probably have guessed) included in TeXLive and other L^AT_EX distributions.

This fresh and continuously updated package is meant to replace older methods of non-Latin text entry that you might find in Web searches, notably babel, which ought to be set aside in 2026 (except in legacy projects that already rely on it).

For full documentation, visit:

ctan.org/pkg/polyglossia

Starting a Project with polyglossia

Remember the package in the preamble:

```
\usepackage{polyglossia}
```

Then, *after* the beginning of the document but *before* actual type, declare the languages and their variants. For example, here is this .tex file's polyglossia declarations:

```
\begin{document}  
\setdefaultlanguage{english}  
\setotherlanguage[variant=ancient]{greek}
```


Combining parallel and polyglossia

The simplest way of showing multilingual text in parallel is

```
\begin{Parallel}{0mm}{0mm}  
  \text<language>\ParallelLText{<ancient text 1>}  
  \ParallelRText{<modern text>}  
  \ParallelPar  
  \text<language>\ParallelLText{<ancient text 2>}  
  \ParallelRText{<modern text 2>}  
\end{Parallel}
```

but since this is tedious for more than a few lines, I remind everyone of `reledpar` and `reledmac` for longer and/or more complicated parallel text displays.

BibLaTeX – comprehensive citation and bibliography management, capable of being interlinked with a variety of citation managers (Zotero, JabRef, etc.)

TeXStudio and other graphical front-ends – LaTeX can be written in any plain text editor, but a designated LaTeX writing environment improves efficiency and helps correct code errors

Designated typeface packages, e.g. **Serto** for Syriac

microtype for small adjustments to type, such as improved automatic hyphenation (a personal favorite)